MUSEUM

THE HOME THAT WAS

A soon-to-launch gallery at the Partition Museum in Delhi will showcase artefacts capturing 'The Lost Homeland of Sindh'



LOOKING BACK IN TIME (Clockwise from the right) 'The Lost Homeland of Sindh' gallery at the Partition Museum in Delhi; and Kishwar Desai (left) with Aruna Madnani

Photographs by RAJWANT RAWAT





Across much of the literature, cultural discourse and historiography around the Partition of India, stories from Punjab and Bengal tend to dominate—these were, after all, the places where the most bloodshed and suffering took place during the 1946-48 period. However, the Sindh region also saw substantial migration in this era, with one big qualitative difference. While the Punjabi and Bengali migrants or refugees had states or regions they could call 'home' in the newly-formed India, Sindhi migrants had no such recourse. Partially as a result of this, today those migrants and their families lament the diminishing influence of Sindhi food, language and culture.

The Partition Museum in Delhi, in association with the Sindhi Culture Foundation, is launching a new gallery called 'The Lost Homeland of Sindh'. Aruna Madnani from the Sindhi Culture Foundation is the curator for this Sindh-specific gallery. Following the style of the existing galleries at the Partition Museum, 'The Lost Homeland of Sindh' will feature a range of artefacts across media—recreations of ancestral homes, objects carried by Sindhi refugees during their exodus, news clippings from the late 1940s, video interviews with Sindhi migrants/ refugees that visitors can watch/ listen to on headphones.

Kishwar Desai, chairperson of the Arts and Cultural Heritage Trust, which runs the Partition Museum, says, "Aruna Madnani, myself and a few others who had been involved with the Museum from day one, wanted a gallery dedicated to Sindh for a long time. Like Punjabi or Bengali migrants, Sindhis were people who lost everything: their land, their families, their culture, and they rebuilt everything here from scratch, in a lot of cases. These stories deserved to be told."

Even before the creation of this gallery, the Partition Museum had always featured a number of historically important exhibits pertaining to Sindh. For example, there is a news clipping that talks about Harijans in Sindh being forcibly prevented from migration—the Pakistani authorities cited 'the Essential Services Ordinance' to keep the Harijans (most of whom were engaged in janitorial/cleaning work) in Pakistan. Choithram Gidwani, the then president of Sindh's Provincial Congress Committee, wrote to B.R. Ambedkar (then the law minister of India) complaining about this and requesting help. Similarly, there are video interviews with migrants who tell us the story of how Gandhidham (in Kutch, Gujarat) was visualised and set up as a place of resettlement for Sindhi migrants. A piece of cloth embroidered by a Sindhi migrant, photographs of 'Sindhi camps' in Delhi and elsewhere are other pertinent examples.

"The response to the Partition Museum, especially from Sindhi visitors, has been fabulous and so heartening," says Desai. "We hope that they will find their voices represented in 'The Lost Homeland of Sindh'. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha